Keepers of the Light

Lighthouses once marked every dangerous stretch of the northern coast. Their keepers lived in isolation for months, trimming wicks, polishing lenses and recording the weather in heavy logbooks that now fill the shelves of regional archives.

The introduction of electric lamps changed the work completely. A single technician could now maintain several towers, visiting each one only when an alarm reported a fault. Within two decades most keepers' cottages stood empty or were sold as holiday homes.

Historians who study the logbooks describe a remarkably consistent routine. Entries begin with the barometric pressure and the direction of the wind, continue with a note on visibility, and end with a short remark about ships that passed during the night.

Some keepers added personal observations: the arrival of migrating birds, the death of a neighbour, a storm that shattered the lantern glass. These marginal notes have become a valuable source for researchers interested in everyday life on remote islands.

Today several towers have been restored as museums. Visitors climb the narrow stairs, look out over the water and read reproductions of the old logbooks, written in a careful hand by people who rarely saw another face for weeks at a time.

Preservation remains expensive. Salt air corrodes metal fittings, wind loosens the stonework, and the specialised glass of the old lenses can no longer be manufactured. Local volunteers raise money every summer to keep the most important buildings standing.